

Staff Days — Week 1, Day 5 (Fri Jul 31)

Morning — *Find Your Feathers*

0:55–1:03 (setup) · 1:06–1:35 (Joe's report-out)

Opened by Will running a live morning launch on the whole room — solo cup towers, with a curveball at three minutes where teams could walk around and steal ideas but not touch anything. Alpha Raleigh won at 202cm. The closing question tied it to the week's slogan: **when we use each other as resources as the org gets bigger, we get better.**

The exercise

Find Your Feathers is the annual root-cause exercise, run after every session — five times a school year. The premise: **we cannot build for tomorrow without rigorously investigating every mistake from the past**, and we don't walk into Session 1 repeating last year's.

The DoorDash story. Austin delivery times were 49 minutes against 35 everywhere else. Ops tried broad fixes — more drivers, smaller zones, sub-markets — and nothing moved. Then one person pulled every single order and read them row by row, and found one restaurant, a sports bar near UT called Feathers, dragging the whole market. One root cause, fixed overnight.

The application. A campus dashboard shows 96% love of school, 69% preferring school to vacation. Most organizations high-five at that number. The Alpha question is *who are the 4%?* Then you go to the level view, where each row is a kid, and find the ones at 75% and 80% and go deep on them. Averages make us look good and hide every problem; **the data is at the edges.**

Three angles reviewed: **every student who didn't get the three commitments, every new guide hire that didn't work out, every family that didn't re-enroll.** Ask why five times. Guides broke out by the level they served last year; Michelle worked guide attrition; Heather, the DOPs, and Mackenzie worked non-re-enrollment family by family.

Joe's framing in the report-out

The two-way diagnosis. For any failure to deliver the three commitments, first ask whether *you* misdelivered something you own and can fix — bad motivational approach, material too hard or too easy. If the answer is no, we did this as well as we can and it still didn't work, then the problem moves **upstream to admissions**: those students shouldn't be coming. Coach families out at the front end rather than enrolling them and then spending a year trying to convince them the model is right. This is why the behavioral model needs to be explicit and given to parents before they opt in.

Fix it before you multiply it. The example that made the point: one high schooler at a campus last year was the only high schooler, felt isolated, and left. Alpha is running high school at **six** campuses this year — so that's one problem about to become six. The fix is a floor of three students plus a dedicated high school guide at each campus. "It's a lot harder to solve that problem when it's six times bigger than it is when it's that one student."

Escalate repeated problems. Across the network and four years of history, someone has almost certainly seen your exact problem before. Next week's cross-collaboration meeting exists for the fixes that need another group's help.

Feathers reported from the floor

- **Rolling admissions and belonging.** An L1 student who joined in Session 3 reported that peers weren't uplifting and he lacked belonging — root causes: older for his level, mid-year entry, no immediate best friend. Proposed fixes: a differentiated boot camp check chart for mid-year entrants, structured one-on-one lunches, a boot camp buddy, a town hall self-introduction. Joe's response: pull the data on mid-year entrants vs. day-one starters and decide whether to fix the onboarding or restrict enrollment to two intake blocks a year.
- **Guide transition.** TSA flagged Session 5 love-of-school decline tied partly to stagnating XP and partly to guide turnover between levels and campuses. Joe acknowledged this is his single most common parent complaint, and named the underlying position: Alpha has many great guides, unlike a traditional school with only a few, so the message to parents is "tell me if you love the *new* guide." He didn't claim to have the transition mechanics solved and asked staff days to produce the answer. High school added the concrete ask: **a central hub where a new guide can get up to speed fast on what a student has mastered, at what level, and what motivates them** — twelve years of data that currently lives in the heads of long-tenured guides. Joe agreed it should be built and made accessible to every guide.
- **Workshop pass rates and skill progression.** Kids were failing workshops because there was no cross-session skill progression — no path to acquire the prerequisites. Joe's parallel: you can't pass chemistry without mastering algebra, and life skills need the same prereq structure and the same ability to place a transfer student, the way a MAP test places a kid in math. This is what AlphaCore is meant to solve.
- **Town hall safety.** An Austin L1 student didn't feel safe speaking up. Fixes: teach both sides from the start, pre- and post-coach the mayors with game film, and cap town hall circles at 15–20 instead of 30.

Joe's aside on both sides: two Alpha High students — one avowed socialist, one free-market capitalist and close friends — attended a Stanford class on Marx and argued each other's positions so convincingly that a Stanford student congratulated the capitalist on her commitment to Marxism. "That is the kind of person we want to graduate."

Joe closed and left for San Francisco (Founder School event, plus a Presidio campus tour).

Post-Lunch Tee-Up — *The Boot Camp Check Chart*

1:49–1:55

The last build of the week and the most concrete: turning the standardized behavior curriculum for the four core life skills — **receiving feedback, uplifting others, upholding community standards, working independently** — into actual student-facing checks.

The standards are already mapped per grade level for end of boot camp and end of year (e.g. an L2 standard: complete 120% of core skills XP goals for a week without redirection; create and maintain a month-long troubleshooting log). The job in breakouts was to convert each standard into an actionable challenge plus a measurement.

Why students will care: completing the boot camp check chart unlocks Alpha wallet spending power at the Emporium, the year-long check chart, and the signature life skills. Work on the regular check chart pauses during boot camp, with the exception that anything already earned (like a passed mastery test) isn't redone.

Clarifications given: students complete only their own grade's standards, not the cumulative stack. The check chart follows every student who joins mid-year, so it doubles as the rolling-admissions onboarding path. The case of a student who didn't complete their grade's check chart but has aged up was tabled.

Target: boot camp check charts, items, and measurements ready to ship pre-K through 8th grade for day one.

Closing — Alpha Summer recognition

3:53–4:04

Level-up recognition first: guide assistants who became guides, guides who became lead guides. The point made was that growth here is hard-earned and objective, and the path is to crush the core of your role and deliver the three commitments.

Alpha Summer by the numbers: nearly **2,000 kids**, **177 guides**, and **201,000 combined miles traveled** — still running in the Hamptons, Kirkland, and Nashville next week. **97%** of campers loved it, **96%** said their guide truly got to know them, and roughly **50%** would pick a week of Alpha over vacation — carrying the school-year stats into summer. Over **1,200 kids were offered admission**, more than double the prior figure.

Awards given: Chris for five cities in seven weeks (most moves of any guide), with honorable mentions to Brittany, Evan Orr, Naftali, Megan Becker, and Sean Finney; **Leah** for 100% of kids saying their guide truly got to know them; **Jen Maddox** for a perfect summer — 58 kids, four weeks, two campuses, 100% love of Alpha Summer every week — with Ree and Tim Sheehy also sweeping; **Allison, Cameron, and Emma** for the highest rates of kids preferring Alpha Summer to vacation (57–60%); and **Lorraine** for the Breakthrough Award, 100% of her kids saying they did something they didn't think they could do.

The stated acknowledgment: "We know it was a grind, we know it was wild, but you pulled it off."

Week 2 goes home — back to campuses for tactical Session 1 building. Calendar A starts **August 12**.